HTML5 quick reference

Page skeleton

`<!doctype html>`	First line. Tells the browser this is HTML5.
`<html lang="en-AU">`	Wraps the page; sets the language for screen readers.
`<meta charset="utf-8">`	Displays apostrophes and accents correctly.
`<meta name="viewport" …>`	Fits the page to phone screens.
`<title>…</title>`	Tab name and search result title. Describe the page.
`<body>`	Everything people see.

Structure (landmarks)

`<header>`	Site title, logo, top navigation.
`<nav>`	A main set of links.
`<main>`	The main content. One per page.
`<section>` / `<article>`	A themed group / a stand-alone item such as a news story.
`<aside>`	Related, but not essential.
`<footer>`	Copyright, contact, small print.

Text

`<h1> … <h6>`	Headings by level. One <h1>; don't skip levels.
`<p>`	A paragraph.
`<strong>`	Important (not just bold).
`<em>`	Stressed emphasis (not just italic).
`<ul> / <ol> + <li>`	Unordered / ordered list items.
`<blockquote>`	A quotation from another source.

Links

`<a href="https://…">`	Another site: absolute address.
`<a href="policies/leave.html">`	Your site: relative path.
`<a href="#contact">`	Same page: jumps to id="contact".
`<a href="mailto:…">`	Email: show the address in the link text.

A complete starter page

```
<!doctype html>
<html lang="en-AU">
  <head>
    <meta charset="utf-8">
    <meta name="viewport"
content="width=device-width, initial-
scale=1">
    <title>Leave policy · Staff hub</title>
  </head>
  <body>
    <header><h1>Staff hub</h1></header>
    <main>…</main>
    <footer>© 2026 Example Co.</footer>
  </body>
</html>
```

Before you publish

Check your page in the W3C Markup Validation Service (validator.w3.org), then tab through it with the keyboard only. Can you reach and use everything?

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Images, tables and forms

Images

`<img src alt width height>`	img has no closing tag.
`alt="Short description"`	Informative image: what matters in this context.
`alt=""`	Decorative image: screen readers skip it.
`width / height`	Stops the page jumping while images load.

Tables

`<caption>`	Names the table. First inside <table>.
`<thead> / <tbody>`	Header rows / data rows.
`<th scope="col">`	Column header.
`<th scope="row">`	Row header.
`<td>`	A data cell.

Forms

`<label for="email">`	Visible label linked to the field's id.
`<input id="email" type="email">`	Type gives the right keyboard and checks.
`required`	The form won't send until it's filled in.
`<fieldset> + <legend>`	Groups radio buttons or checkboxes under a question.
`<textarea>`	Several lines of text.
`<button type="submit">`	Sends the form. Use a real button, not a div.

Attributes you'll use often

`id="contact"`	A unique name: link targets and labels.
`lang="en-AU"`	Language of the page or a phrase.
`href / src`	Where a link goes / where an image comes from.
`type`	The kind of input or button.
`autocomplete="email"`	Lets browsers fill in known details.
`class`	A hook for CSS styles.

Common mistakes

"Click here" links · alt text that starts with "Image of" · placeholder text used instead of a label · headings picked for size, not level · tables used for layout.

Semantic HTML in one line

Choose each element for what the content *is*, not how it looks. Use CSS for the look.

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